Competitor 1: UTEP Dining Website

Type: Direct competitor and existing campus alternative.

What it offers: The portal lists dining locations and hours and includes a "What's Open Now" section. The Pick N' Shovel page also provides a menu date selector, nutrition information, and dietary and allergen filters.

Walkthrough observation: I opened the hours page, selected Pick N' Shovel, changed the menu date, and enabled the vegetarian filter. The filter accepted the selection, but the reviewed menu area did not provide enough item information to confirm current availability.

Strength: It already brings campus-specific information together. DineCheck cannot claim that campus hours or dietary filters are unique features.

Weakness: The reviewed menu area did not clearly distinguish scheduled menu items from food currently available at the counter. There was not enough item information to verify availability before visiting.

Question to investigate: Can students distinguish a scheduled menu from food that is actually available at the counter?

Possible DineCheck advantage: Clearly distinguish location open, counter serving, and item available, with visible update times. This advantage still needs testing.

Where DineCheck falls short: UTEP Dining is the official campus source and students already use it to check hours. DineCheck has not yet shown a dependable staff update process or that students would open a second tool.

Competitor 2: Nutrislice

Type: Direct competitor offering digital dining menus.

What it offers: The Nutrislice app provides daily menus, food descriptions, nutrition information, allergen and dietary filters, and favorite locations. The University of New Hampshire's published descriptions also list a nutrition calculator.

Walkthrough observation: UNH's public menu stayed blank in a browser. Team 10 then installed the Nutrislice app on mobile devices, and menu data loaded as soon as the University of New Hampshire location was selected in the iOS app. No login was required and no pricing was offered. [Add whether sold-out items or update times were shown.]

Strength: Its menus, nutrition tools, and filters overlap with DineCheck's proposed features. DineCheck cannot claim these features are unique.

Weakness to investigate: Our walkthrough record does not yet establish whether students can distinguish scheduled menu items from food currently available at the counter. This is an evidence gap, not a confirmed platform weakness.

Question to investigate: Does a campus implementation clearly communicate sold-out items, when availability was last updated, and when information may be outdated?

Possible DineCheck advantage: A simpler, campus-specific workflow that clearly separates location open, counter serving, and item available, with visible update times. This advantage still needs testing.

Where DineCheck falls short: DineCheck is currently a proposed solution and has not demonstrated dependable availability updates or a working staff update process. It also has not shown that its workflow is easier to use than Nutrislice’s existing tools.

Competitor 3: Google Maps

Type: Indirect competitor; a general restaurant-discovery and navigation alternative.

What it offers: Google Maps helps users find restaurants and get directions. Restaurant profiles can include opening status, hours, addresses, reviews, website links, and menu information.

Walkthrough observation: I searched for restaurants near UTEP and opened Crave Kitchen & Bar. The profile displayed opening status, hours, an address, reviews, directions, and a restaurant website link. The session also displayed a limited-view notice, which restricted the review.

Strength: It combines restaurant discovery with practical information students need to choose and reach a location, including options on and off campus.

Weakness: The reviewed profile did not establish whether a particular food item was currently available. Opening status and general restaurant information alone were insufficient to confirm item availability.

Question to investigate: Can students confirm that a particular food item is available without leaving Maps or contacting the restaurant?

Possible DineCheck advantage: Staff-confirmed campus item availability presented alongside dining hours and visible update times. A campus-specific workflow could help students decide where to eat between classes, but this advantage still needs testing.

Where DineCheck falls short: DineCheck's proposed scope covers campus dining locations. Google Maps supports a broader search for restaurants on and off campus and combines discovery with directions and reviews. DineCheck has also not yet demonstrated a dependable process for keeping item availability current.